

The Morning Newspaper

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

95° / 75°

Overcast, 3% rain, wind up to 12 mph

Tomorrow: 92° / 74°, overcast

Sunrise 7:22 · Sunset 19:20

○ Waning gibbous

Trump Rejects Iran's Hormuz Proposal as Oil Surges, Markets Slide

A stalemate over the Strait of Hormuz sent oil higher and dragged stocks and bonds down on fears of renewed inflation.

WORLD & TECH

Amodei to Dine With Trump Amid AI Safety Debate

BLOOMBERG

Anthropic chief Dario Amodei is set to have dinner with President Trump, their first private meeting after months of friction over a Pentagon contract dispute and export controls placed on Anthropic's Mythos model earlier this year. Amodei has pushed for the AI industry to slow down and partner with government on safety rules, while Trump argues regulation would let China pull ahead. Separately, Australia's Senate has asked both Amodei and OpenAI's Sam Altman to testify at an inquiry into AI regulation.

Nvidia Lifts Buyback to \$235 Billion, Unveils Agent Safety Platform

MARKET WIRES

Nvidia announced a \$150 billion increase to its share buyback authorization, lifting the total to \$235 billion, and launched an Open Agent Safety Platform aimed at AI deployments. The news didn't stop chip stocks from sliding, as the sector index fell more than 1% alongside a broader market pullback driven by Middle East tensions.

Hurricane Polo Takes Aim at Mexico's Pacific Coast

AP

Hurricane Polo is churning toward Mexico's Pacific coast, prompting storm warnings for coastal communities. Forecasters are watching its track closely as it strengthens over warm Pacific waters. Farther north, a Nor'easter is battering the U.S. East Coast with heavy rain and coastal flooding.

Consumer Sentiment Sinks Near Historic Low

YAHOO FINANCE

The University of Michigan's consumer sentiment index sits at 48.1, near record lows, with households expecting 4.6% inflation over the coming year. Rising borrowing costs, including a 30-year mortgage rate above 7% and a 10-year Treasury yield above 5%, are compounding the gloom for both homebuyers and the White House's economic messaging.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,705.08	-0.49%
Dow Jones	51,605.75	-0.43%
Nasdaq	26,856.31	-0.79%
Russell 2000	2,817.32	-0.71%
VIX	15.87	+6.73%
10-yr yield	5.22	+0.64%
CRYPTO		
Bitcoin	\$83,460	-1.80%
Ethereum	\$2,684.58	-0.86%
STOCKS		
NVDA	\$230.98	+2.63%
AAPL	\$341.90	+0.24%
MSFT	\$507.25	-1.73%
GOOGL	\$340.87	-0.89%
AMZN	\$245.93	-1.50%
META	\$721.00	-4.08%
AVGO	\$350.91	-0.54%
TSLA	\$361.24	-2.92%
SPCX	\$146.21	-1.66%
BRK-B	\$507.01	+0.30%
TSM	\$445.87	-1.05%

Stocks fell across the board after Trump rebuffed Iran's latest offer to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, pushing oil prices up and reviving inflation worries. The Nasdaq led losses as chipmakers slid despite Nvidia's buyback news, while the VIX jumped nearly 7% and the 10-year yield climbed above 5%. Bitcoin and Ethereum eased in sympathy with the broader risk-off mood, giving back some of their recent gains as traders trimmed riskier positions. Defensive names like Berkshire Hathaway and Apple were the rare bright spots, while Meta and Tesla led the S&P's decliners on renewed spending and demand worries.

ON THIS DAY

September 28, 1928: Scottish bacteriologist Alexander Fleming returned from vacation to find a mold had killed the staph bacteria in a petri dish he'd left uncovered — the accidental discovery that led to penicillin, the world's first true antibiotic.

FROM THE FEEDS · FULL TEXT IN SECTION B

NAUTILUS

Fire in the Brain: How Psychosis May Arise When the Body Attacks Itself — rare cases where the immune system's own antibodies attack brain cells and mimic psychiatric illness.

NAUTILUS

What Do You Know About the Deep-Sea Barbie Pig? — a tour of the ocean's strangest-named creatures, from the Barbie Pig to the Ghost Octopus.

LONGREADS

A Graveyard Shift with Britain's Gen Z Undertakers — could apprentice undertakers be an answer to youth unemployment?

AEON

Paternity is Poetical — poetry and neuroscience both push back on the old idea that fatherhood and creativity are at odds.

AEON

Affect Theory (video) — 1990s thinkers turned from language back to feeling and the body to explain what shapes us.

TRICYCLE

Beauty, Being, and Becoming — what flowers can teach about gratitude, generosity, and letting go.

NAUTILUS

Fire in the Brain: How Psychosis May Arise When the Body Attacks Itself

GEORGIA MICHELMAN · NAUTILUS · SEP 28, 2026

A deep look at the emerging science of autoimmune psychosis and what it means for diagnosis and treatment.

This story was originally published by Knowable Magazine. Peter Jones once treated a patient with strikingly vivid hallucinations of animals. During ward visits, the patient would stroke and interact with the critters “in as real a way as he was with me,” says Jones, an academic psychiatrist at the University of Cambridge in England.

Antipsychotic drugs did nothing to dissolve these Snow White-esque visions. But when the patient received plasma exchange — a treatment normally reserved for a misbehaving immune system — his hallucinations dissipated.

Clearly, this was not a textbook case of schizophrenia. Rather, the patient’s symptoms stemmed from autoimmune encephalitis, a rare form of brain inflammation that can, in some cases, cause hallucinations and other symptoms of psychosis. When these patients are treated with drugs that tamp down the immune system, the psychotic symptoms often disappear.

Autoimmune encephalitis is usually first identified through testing blood or spinal fluid for certain types of antibodies. If patients test positive for these antibodies, it’s a sign that their immune system may be attacking the brain. Other signs can help to solidify diagnosis: bright patches of inflammation on MRI scans, quickly worsening psychotic symptoms and — importantly — clear neurological symptoms such as seizures.

But Jones’ patient didn’t have those obvious neurological symptoms. If Jones hadn’t suspected an autoimmune cause, the case likely would have been missed.

Some experts suspect that the field of psychiatry is overlooking a small number of patients like this, and they are working to find more of them. They’re considering screening a broader array of psychiatric patients and seeking out new antibodies that may be involved in autoimmune encephalitis.

At the same time, many worry that there’s a risk of planting false hopes and diverting patients from the psychiatric treatments the vast majority will actually need, should autoimmune encephalitis become overdiagnosed.

Landmark Research Paper

The “artificial divide” between the body and the mind that separates the fields of psychiatry and neurology is starting to break down, says Michael Zandi, a neurologist at University College London. Psychosis, for example, can be caused by a mix of mental and biological factors, from psychological trauma to drug abuse to physical diseases or infections (such as syphilis) that alter brain activity. Around 3 percent of people will experience a psychotic episode in their lifetime.

Brain inflammation caused by the body assaulting itself, as in autoimmune encephalitis, has been recognized for the past couple of decades. In the early stages of this condition, many patients develop the core features of psychosis — hallucinations, delusions and agitation — and so are initially sent to psychiatric services.

A landmark paper about this condition came in 2007, when researchers described the cases of 12 women with autoimmune encephalitis. Nine of the patients initially presented with a number of psychosis-like symptoms, while the others mainly had memory loss. All but one devolved into seizures. The researchers found that the women’s conditions were caused by antibodies that bind to the brain’s NMDA receptors, proteins that are involved in many processes in the brain, such as learning and the formation of memories.

The trigger for autoimmune encephalitis, in this case, seemed to be tumors in these patients, 90 percent of which were ovarian. All five tumors the researchers examined contained nerve tissue complete with NMDA receptors. This confused the immune system, which came to recognize the NMDA receptor as foreign and ramped up the manufacture of antibodies that bind to it.

But those antibodies also bound to NMDA receptors in healthy brain tissue, interfering with brain function. Other cells of the immune system gathered to the area, sparking inflammation that, in many of these cases, caused psychosis.

Beyond tumors, experts also think that classic autoimmune encephalitis may be triggered by previous infections such as herpes simplex virus in the brain. But root causes are often mysterious. Only a tiny sliver of psychosis cases are due to autoimmune causes — most experts cap it at 1 to 2 percent of patients. If untreated, these patients may decline into a coma and even die, so to avoid missing them, savvy psychiatrists look for other neurological symptoms, most notably seizures, but also features like catatonia or mouth-twitching.

If these telltale signs of brain inflammation emerge, blood or spinal fluid may be tested for autoantibodies (antibodies that attack the patient’s own tissues). If these tests, often coupled with signs on MRI or EEG brain scans, point to autoimmune encephalitis, patients are rushed into immunotherapy: treatments with drugs to tamp down the overreactive immune system. Many fully recover: “We can get them completely better,” says Zandi.

Autoimmune encephalitis is commonly caused by antibodies that bind to the NMDA receptor, known as NMDAR antibodies. But researchers have uncovered dozens more antibody types that are associated with encephalitis, some of which also appear to produce psychiatric symptoms.

One leading example is LGI1 antibodies, which were discovered in 2010. These antibodies latch onto LGI1 proteins in the brain, preventing them from passing signals between nerve cells. This form of autoimmune encephalitis often causes dementia-like symptoms, leading to initial misdiagnosis. Zandi says he's had patients whose apparent dementia has disappeared after immunotherapy, leaving them "fully independent, back to driving, normal."

University of Oxford psychiatrist Belinda Lennox has observed similarly striking transformations. Around the time of the 2007 paper, she began conducting antibody tests on psychiatric patients whose symptoms seemed to overlap with signs of autoimmune encephalitis, such as quickly shifting psychotic symptoms or neurological features like seizures.

One of Lennox's first patients to test positive for NMDAR antibodies was a young female librarian who had rapidly descended into

paranoia, stopped sleeping and then went mute. Antipsychotic drugs made her condition worse. After the antibodies were detected, the patient was given treatment to remove them from her blood. Within about a week, she was completely better. "That was the sort of mind-blowing moment," Lennox says.

Today, Lennox is fascinated by the possibility of a larger population of psychosis patients whose illness is owed to autoimmune issues that are missed. This might explain why some patients don't respond well to psychiatric treatments. "It's an unexplored tip of the iceberg," she says.

In search of missed patients, for the last decade Lennox has been running a clinical trial called SINAPPS2 to probe whether antibodies can be causing psychosis even in patients who don't have other obvious neurological symptoms such as seizures and comas. Jones of the University of Cambridge is another investigator on the trial.



Continued online (full article about 2873 words). Scan, or visit <https://nautil.us/fire-in-the-brain-how-psychosis-may-arise-when-the-body-attacks-itself-1285334/>

LONGREADS

A Graveyard Shift with Britain's Gen Z Undertakers

CHERI LUCAS ROWLANDS · LONGREADS.COM · SEP 28, 2026

On-the-ground reporting on young apprentices entering funeral work as a answer to youth unemployment.

In this story for Dispatch, Lotte Brundle reports on a surprising trend: young women in the UK are pursuing careers in the death care industry. In a time of high unemployment, funeral home apprenticeships offer an alternative to university, where students accumulate significant debt. While the pay is low and the industry needs to do a better job building awareness that the trajectory exists, the young women who speak to Brundle find the work meaningful and rewarding.

Her inspiration to become an undertaker arrived, as many teenage epiphanies now do, via TikTok. Emily was 15 and had been considering becoming a teacher or journalist when she came across

an American woman documenting life inside her own funeral home. "I'd never considered it as a career," she says. "I didn't know anyone who was an undertaker, but I just thought how interesting it was."

Two hours later, she was still scrolling through the woman's profile, engrossed. Running her own funeral home became Emily's dream.

More stories about death

"In most of the country, executions are a thing of the past. But one state has been carrying them out at a record pace."

"After my husband's death, I had never been more pliable, tender, open, or raw. It was then that I tried E.M.D.R. therapy."

AEON

Paternity is Poetical

DANIEL SWIFT · AEON.CO · SEP 28, 2026

An essay drawing on poetry and neuroscience to argue fatherhood and creativity aren't at odds.

Here's an old story, often told. In Book 6 of the Iliad, Hector – dressed splendidly in bronze armour and a helmet with a horsehair crest – bids farewell to his wife Andromache. She begs him not to return to battle and hands him their newborn son. Hector raises the boy into the air, says a short prayer, and hands him back. 'Go home, attend to your own handiwork / at loom and spindle,' he commands, in Robert Fitzgerald's translation: 'As for the war, / that is for men.'

Hector is a father in the heroic mode, and his parenting style has long been irresistible to artists and writers. Few were shocked when the painter Paul Gauguin left his wife and five children in Denmark to

pursue fame and art in Paris, then Tahiti. Such distance, they say, is good for a child. 'The father, from his distance, supports, protects, nourishes his child,' wrote D H Lawrence in 1922: 'and it is ultimately on the remote but powerful father-love that the infant rests.' Distance is equally necessary for the father who seeks to make art. 'There is no more sombre enemy of good art than the pram in the hall,' wrote Cyril Connolly in *Enemies of Promise* (1938).

This is a deeply self-serving story, of course. It's nice for the male poet not to have to change diapers. But the argument that unsullied privacy is essential to creativity is tenacious. It surfaces when Virginia Woolf writes that 'a woman must have money and a room of

her own if she is to write fiction.’ Contemporary feminists have continued to respond to this archetype of generativity. In Jenny Offill’s novel *Dept. of Speculation* (2014), for example, the narrator vows never to marry but to become ‘an art monster instead’.

But what if domesticity – and specifically parenthood – is in fact generative for artists? What if the cliché of solitary male creativity got it wrong? We may begin with one nursing poet. In his poem ‘Frost at Midnight’, written in the winter of 1797, Samuel Taylor Coleridge pictures himself at home in his cottage on a frosty night. The owls cry outside and the frost rings the trees and he is alone, ‘save that at my side / My cradled infant slumbers peacefully.’ He addresses his infant son:

**Dear Babe, that sleepest cradled by my side,
Whose gentle breathings, heard in this deep calm,**

Fill up the intersperséd vacancies

And momentary pauses of the thought!

He is transported to memories of his own childhood, and then his hopes for his son’s future.

‘Frost at Midnight’ is a poem about caring, in both senses of the word: caring for and caring about. As such, it is a surprising poem about domestic labour, which has invited comment from scholars. ‘What is truly radical about “Frost at Midnight” is Coleridge’s self-representation as a father in the traditional maternal posture of watching over a sleeping baby,’ notes Jonathan Bate. What Bate calls ‘the traditional maternal posture’ is what Hector calls ‘your own handiwork / at loom and spindle’. But perhaps it is not so radical to picture a poet who is equally involved in the work of parenting. Perhaps it is precisely fatherhood that made Coleridge a poet.

What makes ‘Frost at Midnight’ significant in Coleridge’s career is that it represents the crest of the much longer wave of his stylistic development. It is not just a great poem – it is the poem within which he becomes a great poet, and his growth as a poet can be tracked neatly against his experience of becoming a father.

Coleridge was far from home when his son was born. A lost revolutionary, he was always trying to save or at least improve the world, and he was preaching in Birmingham when word came by

letter: Hartley, born to his wife Sara, on 19 September 1796. He met the news with shock and a trio of sonnets. ‘My o’erwhelmed Heart / Trembled, & vacant tears stream’d down my face,’ he wrote in the first of these. He sent this to a friend, and it was published only in 1847, after his death. He wrote another on the journey home, and here imagines that he might arrive to terrible news: ‘when I reach my door, / If heavy looks should tell me thou art dead ...’ They are not charming poems, but repressed; so guarded even when apparently tender, as if he is trying out how he feels in the set form of an Italian sonnet. ‘When I saw it on its mother’s arm, / And hanging at her bosom,’ he confesses in the last of these sonnets: ‘Then I was thrill’d and melted.’ This is a cautious, half-convincing expression of fatherly love. A few days later, he wrote to a friend: ‘in truth, I have seen handsomer babies in my lifetime.’

‘Kubla Khan’, ‘Christabel’, ‘The Rime of the Ancient Mariner’ were all begun or completed within 18 months of his son’s birth

Because Coleridge narrated his moods, and wrote letters that turned into poems, he permits us to reconstruct a detailed timeline of his changing feelings towards his son. Later, it will be an unhappy story, and Hartley will live an unhappy life, but at first it did not seem to be going that way. By December 1796, Coleridge was planning to move his family to a thatched cottage in the village of Nether Stowey in Somerset. He wrote to a friend with enthusiasm: ‘I mean to work very hard as Cook, Butler, Scullion, Shoe-cleaner, occasional Nurse.’ He turned out to love nursing. By the start of February, he was writing to another friend: ‘You would smile to see my eye rolling up to the ceiling in a Lyric fury, and on my knee a Diaper pinned, to warm.’ This moment – of writing while nursing, of diapers and poetic inspiration – is the genesis of ‘Frost at Midnight’.

The creation of the father is also the creation of the poet. In the spring of 1797, Coleridge was writing 50 lines of blank verse a day. He began to develop his ‘conversation poems’, which drew from his letters to friends and family: their language is intimate, domestic; their topics often autobiographical. Towards the end of that year, he turned to what are now called his ‘mystery poems’, and are those for which he is most celebrated: ‘Kubla Khan’, ‘Christabel’, ‘The Rime of the Ancient Mariner’, all of which were begun or completed within 18 months of Hartley’s birth.



Continued online (full article about 3882 words). Scan, or visit <https://aeon.co/essays/when-a-man-becomes-a-father-and-a-poetic-revolution-follows>

TRICYCLE: THE BUDDHIST REVIEW

Beauty, Being, and Becoming

VALERIE BROWN · TRICYCLE.ORG · SEP 28, 2026

A reflective essay using flowers as a lens on gratitude, generosity, and letting go.

Flowers are the prayers of the vegetal world. The plants offer their beauty to the Supreme.

—The Mother, Flowers and Their Messages

All my life I’ve been a sucker for beauty, especially beauty in the form of flowers, plants, and the natural world. I would rather go without food than without flowers. It sounds dramatic—and that’s real for me. I recall a time years ago when I was desperate to touch

the natural world. I was living in a third-floor walk-up hall room in Queens, working at Burger King, and going to City University of New York in Manhattan at night. On my way to school one day, I passed a street vendor selling roses by the bundle in colors of peach, scarlet, and magenta. Time stopped as I stared at them. I heard them whisper two words to every part of my body: “Take me.”

In those days I had a skin-tight budget and lived mostly on chicken livers at less than one dollar for a small container, which I could buy at a cut-rate grocery store down the street. I looked at the flowers. They looked at me. I calculated the cost in my head. Twenty bucks. TWENTY BUCKS. I looked at the vendor, a savvy, street-smart Latinx man with a baby face and hefty hands. He saw my dilemma; he had seen this before. The flowers would cost my entire food budget for the week. I knew (and he knew) the flowers were outside my budget, but that was alright because I wasn't buying roses. I was buying the luxurious, overabundant desire to touch and smell something beautiful, like spring wind in a turquoise sky, warm rain pooling in the moonlight, or a slow lifting fog, and that was priceless, so the roses were a bargain.

Roses remind me of the importance of beauty for beauty's sake. Beauty is complete and gives generously. It is a homecoming that excavates an inner sensitivity and sureness that is present, waiting, and expectant. Growing up in Brooklyn, I knew the natural world was there, generous and beautiful, of course, but at that time it seemed distant, rough, and inaccessible. The gentle sun came up and set over the parched terrain of Bushwick's row homes, concrete sidewalks, and chain-link fences. To see and feel grass, my brothers Alex and Robert and I would run through Evergreens Cemetery on Bushwick Avenue, one of the great urban forests of New York City, paying little or no mind to the lives marked by tombstones. We were there to smell the green, green grass and feel it squishy under our sneakers and get close to muscular trees like a hundred-year-old sweet gum, black oaks, and white ash trees. We were chasing an emerging feeling, a fleeting sense of the timeless present, moments that glow in their luminosity and cannot be possessed but are lived with a slower presence of the immediate now.

For me, this time spent at Evergreens was more than dodging city streets. I was safe among the trees and flowers emerging in the spring, and the leaves falling in autumn. They wanted nothing from me and gave me beauty not as a luxury concept but as a birthright to be known, felt, and lived. My mother, a single parent working two jobs to support four kids, took in boarders in our sturdy brick house with oak doors and beveled glass. She filled every room, including the tiny hall room, little more than a closet, with older alcoholic Black men who had seen better times. Innocent and available, I was left in the house and subjected to sexual abuse by these tenants until they left or ran out of money to pay rent. The terror of the abuse in this strange place was adjacent to the beauty of Evergreens, the daffodils and cherry blossoms in spring, the autumn leaves in full glorious color. Even with the terror, or perhaps because of it, I held on to the beauty of Evergreens that could not be damaged, destroyed, or diminished, that was beyond the physical landscape and pointed instead to a horizon within me, tranquil and unstained.

I was safe among the trees and flowers emerging in the spring, and the leaves falling in autumn. They wanted nothing from me and gave me beauty not as a luxury concept but as a birthright to be known, felt, and lived.

That moment with the street vendor years ago led me to a lifelong love of not just roses but also flower gardening. When I moved from Brooklyn into my barn-like home outside Philadelphia, and after my husband left and we divorced, I set out to create something beautiful from the death of the marriage, to transform the "mud" of the marriage into a "lotus" garden. To paraphrase Wendy Johnson, one of the founders of the Garden Program at Green Gulch Zen Center in California, there are three good reasons to grow flowers: for beauty, for the coming apart of beauty, and to begin again. This wisdom aligns with many Buddhist teachings and, for me, especially the teachings on impermanence (anitya). The beauty of growing flowers is a living lesson on impermanence.

The Buddha asked all practitioners to manifest, moment-to-moment, the insight of impermanence. As a Dharmacharya, a dharma teacher in the Plum Village tradition, I feel especially drawn to learn the inescapable reality of impermanence not as a theory but as an ongoing realization and practice I can share with others. Ultimately, everything and everyone changes despite sometimes resisting change. Flowers decompose; a child becomes an adult; day becomes night. This calls for practice with the shifting nature of reality: to love, to care, to accept, to occupy space and time, to release, to let go.

This loving and letting go is the essence of gardening, and it was a lesson I relearned in my garden through an old flowering Wisteria sinensis. When I moved into my home, the wisteria grew over the cottage roof and threatened to rip off the shingles with its branching, leafless, wooden tentacles. Slowly, little by little, I cut back the vine and trained it over a substantial wooden pergola. In late spring, the plant bloomed a voluptuous cascade of blue to purple flowers, perfuming the air. Impermanence teaches that things ripen, flower in their time, and fade away in a continuous cycle of beauty, being, becoming, and nonbeing. It teaches gratitude and appreciation for the unrepeating wonder of each day, each moment.

Impermanence teaches that things ripen, flower in their time, and fade away in a continuous cycle of beauty, being, becoming, and nonbeing. It teaches gratitude and appreciation for the unrepeating wonder of each day, each moment.

What have I learned from this experience? Because of impermanence, I have learned that I can change my relationship to the abuse that happened to me. I acknowledge the beauty and violence inherent in life. I am aware that the people who abused me were abused themselves and were caught in a system and structure that perpetuated their despair and depredation. I'm aware of both the violence I experienced and the beauty of the Evergreens. Today, both the beauty and the violence are available to support me in transforming my life to be of service to others, to grow compassion not only for myself but also for victims and perpetrators of violence and abuse.

From Love Is Liberation: Five Contemplations for Daily Ethical Living (2026), courtesy of Parallax Press, parallax.org.

NAUTILUS

What Do You Know About the Deep-Sea Barbie Pig?

DAVID NIELD · NAUTILUS · SEP 28, 2026

A lighter tour of the ocean's oddest-named creatures, good for a quick break.

“The abyssal plain covers half of the surface of the Earth, but far less than one percent of it has ever been seen,” begins the trailer for new deep-sea documentary, *How Deep Is Your Love*. Thanks to the film, and the efforts of director Eleanor Mortimer and a team of biologists, we’ve now got a much closer look at one part of this plain, and the weird and wonderful marine creatures inhabiting it.

The exact location: the Clarion-Clipperton fracture zone in the Pacific. It’s about as remote as it gets—at least a 12-day voyage from any landmass. It’s an oceanographer’s paradise, teeming as it is with unknown life. After all, as the doc points out, around 90 percent of underwater life-forms have yet to be identified and named.

That naming process can take years, which is why the film crew and the scientists involved came up with nicknames for a lot of the creatures they came across. We’ve got Barbie Pig, a type of sea cucumber with a bright pink body, stubby “legs,” and spiky protuberances on top. There’s also the Ping Pong Sponge—what looks like a ping-pong ball on a stick—and the Headless Chicken Monster, a floating translucent sack containing vibrant, coiled innards. As for Caspar the Ghost Octopus, you can probably guess what it looks like from the name.

Some of the species caught on camera have been identified before, but got nicknames anyway. For example: the sea cucumber *Psychropotes semperiana*, with a distinctive raised “sail,” goes by the moniker of “gummy squirrel.” There’s also the chunky, purplish *Psychronaetes hanseni* sea cucumber, nicknamed “The King.”

Despite the funny names, however, there’s a serious message to the film. The seabed, some 3 miles under the waves, is a target for industrial mining. One of the big questions the documentary asks is whether the benefits gained from mining outweigh the potential environmental costs. Similarly, *How Deep Is Your Love* doesn’t shy away from the difficulties of scientific work like this either. To be properly studied and identified, creatures must be captured, killed, and brought to the surface, a process that the film soberly chronicles.

“It’s the challenge of the deep sea,” Mortimer told *The Guardian*. “Most people never go there, and yet it’s a huge part of our planet we need to connect with. That was the motive behind the film. I want people to fall in love with the deep sea, I want people to connect with it.”

That, of course, is where the Barbie Pig’s star turn comes in.

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